

Love, Family and Private Life in Contemporary China

“儿孙自有儿孙福,没有儿孙我享福”

Children may find their own fortune, but with no children, the fortune is entirely mine

The Demographic Paradox

6.8M↓

Marriage registrations 2024

All-time historical low

1.09↓

Total fertility rate, 2022

Replacement level = 2.1

-2.08M

Population change, 2023

First decline in 60 years

- State response: three-child policy (2021), brideprice regulation (2024), provincial cash subsidies → minimal measurable effect on fertility
- Paradox: individuals opt out at record rates — yet family pressure, matchmaking markets, and marriage norms have not retreated
 - Marriage parks overflow on weekends; matchmaking apps log record downloads; brideprice disputes escalate nationwide

Analytical Framework

PROBLÉMATIQUE

To what extent does China's socioeconomic modernisation transform traditional family norms, or perpetuate them in new forms, mediated by class structure, gender inequality, and the privatisation of reproductive costs?

Reading 01

Yang Hu (2016)

Partner selection

Class reproduction through marriage markets

Reading 02

Zhou Yun (2025)

Sex preference

Internalisation of gender inequality

Reading 03

Zhang et al. (2023)

Fertility behaviour

Structural barriers to stated intentions

READING 01

Yang Hu (2016)

门当户对 Marriage of Matching Doors:
Marital Sorting on Parental Background in China

Demographic Research, Vol. 35 (2016), pp. 557–580

Research Question & Theoretical Context

Core question

门当户对 — **matching doors tradition**

Does this tradition persist in contemporary China?

Classical meaning: marriage as exchange between families of equivalent social standing — not merely between individuals

"Doors" symbolise the extended clan. Social visibility is constitutive — matching must be publicly legible

Yang Hu's innovation: examines whether fathers and fathers-in-law are socially matched — the true test of 'matching doors'

Two competing narratives

Individualisation thesis (Yan 2009; Davis 2014)

Marriage has become privatised and de-institutionalised; the 1950 Marriage Law and market reform freed individuals from family control over spousal choice

Resilience thesis (Hu & Scott 2016)

Traditional family values persist across generations despite social upheaval; the hukou system (reinstated 1951) institutionalises rural-urban barriers in the marriage market

This study provides the first nationally representative test of whether parental background shapes marital outcomes net of all individual-level factors

Data, Method & Core Findings

Data & method

- 2006 CGSS, N = 6,831 married couples
- Father's occupational status (4-tier EGP scheme) + hukou type (rural/urban)
- Log-linear models: isolates net parental background effects after controlling for spousal assortative mating and intergenerational mobility

H1a

Father's occupational status → spouse's occupation: significant net association even after controlling for own status and intergenerational mobility

H1b

Father's hukou exerts an independent effect on spouse's occupation above and beyond occupational rank

KEY FINDING

Father & father-in-law: significant net association in both occupational status and hukou type — family-to-family matching persists

87.3%

both fathers share the same hukou type (both rural or both urban). Marriage in China remains a family affair.

Contemporary Resonance & Critical Appraisal

"孔雀女遇凤凰男" — "A peacock girl meets a phoenix man"

The viral social media trope encapsulating Yang Hu's findings: a class mismatch between an urban-privileged woman and a rural-background man, producing friction over money, family obligations, and social ambition — Yang Hu's regression tables rendered as drama.

Bourdieuian framing

Habitus naturally gravitates individuals toward similar class backgrounds without explicit parental coercion. 'Free love' is the surface form; class endogamy is the structural outcome.

Double disadvantage

Rural men face constrained occupational mobility and limited marriage market access simultaneously. Hukou is not just administrative — it is a lifetime social positioning device.

Critical limitations

Data from 2006: China's mobile internet, new middle class, and platform economy post-date this. Mothers' occupational status omitted — likely underestimates the full strength of family-background effects.

READING 02

Zhou Yun (2025)

How Gendered Lived Experiences Shape
Sex Preference Attitudes in Contemporary Urban China

Journal of Marriage and Family, 87(1), 365–391 (2025)

The Core Puzzle & Quantitative Findings

Core puzzle:

Why do highly educated, gender-egalitarian urban Chinese women still prefer sons? Education should weaken son preference — the data contradicts this.

Mixed methods design

- Quantitative: CGSS 2010–2018, six waves pooled, N = 1,532 (highly educated urban women, born post-1978)
- Gender role ideology index: 5 items (men's capability, employment primacy, domestic labour division)
- Multinomial logistic regression, relative risk ratios (RRR)
- Qualitative: 70 in-depth interviews, Beijing & Nanjing, 2016–2017 · Interpretative Phenomenological Analysis (IPA)

Key null result

Gender role ideology does NOT predict son preference

$RRR = 0.80 \cdot 95\% \text{ CI } (0.58-1.09) \cdot \text{non-significant}$

Among the 115 women with exclusive son preference:

- 71% reject the claim that men are more capable
- 90% reject men's employment primacy in downturns
- 85% support equal division of housework

→ *Son preference and gender egalitarianism can coexist — conventional theory cannot explain this*

Two Qualitative Logics of Son Preference

Logic 1 · Shielding from gendered hardship

Women draw on personal experiences of gender injustice to frame son preference as maternal duty — not a devaluation of girls

- *Yinuo (26): There is too much hardship in a woman's life*
- Bailey (28): navigated school as an overweight girl — does not want her child to face beauty-standard tyranny
- Raina (26): mistreated by grandparents favouring her male cousin — 'gender discrimination is pervasive, everybody knows it'
- Hope (25): sees her sister lose her natal home upon marriage — a daughter will no longer have her original home

Key: these women explicitly reject male superiority — their son preference is driven by acute awareness of gender injustice, not indifference to it

Logic 2 · Anticipated parental burden

In a gender-unequal society, ensuring a daughter's wellbeing requires qualitatively more intensive and vigilant parenting

- Luna (29, lawyer): explicit risk inventory — sexual safety, career penalties from motherhood, social pressure to marry, pressure not to marry
- *Molly (28): Girls are more vulnerable: if I have a daughter, I would need to put in far more effort*
- Shali (35): visceral anxiety from news reports of girls abused in daycare — 'mothers of daughters are always anxious'

These logics appear nuanced and modern — but ultimately complement, rather than disrupt, patriarchal familial expectations for having at least one son

Behavioural Implications & Theoretical Contribution

Second-birth desires among 12 interviewed mothers (Table 6)

First child = daughter

Universally desired a second child as long as husband or in-laws preferred a son — regardless of the mother's own preference

First child = son

Did not plan further children — even those who personally preferred daughters. The demand for at least one son is structurally satisfied.

Conclusion: regardless of the woman's private reasoning, entrenched patriarchal familial expectations dominate second-birth outcomes

Eklund (2016)

"Daughter aversion" is conceptually distinct from devaluation of girls — a new analytical category needed

Daminger (2020)

Gender egalitarians may perpetuate gender-unequal outcomes through de-gendered processes

Zhou Yun's contribution

Nuanced logics of 'shielding' and 'hard work' whitewash rather than disrupt patriarchal family expectations

READING 03

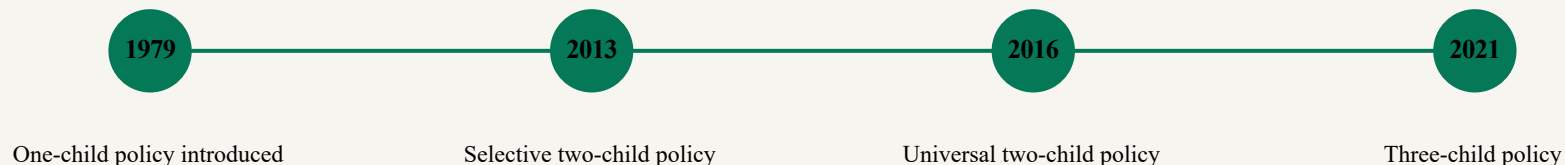
Zhang, Yang, Kim & Fong (2023)

Why Parents' Fertility Plans Changed in China: A Longitudinal Study

The China Quarterly, 253, 183–196 (2023)

Research Design & Policy Context

Policy timeline:



Policy paradox: even after full liberalisation (2016), 84.86% of urban one-child families chose NOT to have a second child (2014–2018 data)

Methodological innovation: genuine longitudinal design

- Origin: 1999 survey of 8th/9th graders at a Dalian middle school (N = 406)
- Representative subsample of 47: annual surveys 2008–2021 (13 years across prime fertility ages)
- In-depth interviews at each pivotal life stage: single, newlywed, child aged 1, 4, school-entry · Spouses interviewed separately within days
- *Key advantage: captures how and why intentions change — cross-sectional studies can only take a snapshot*

The Intention–Behaviour Gap

62.6%

planned to have two children · 2014–2015 survey, N = 391



4.3%

actually had two children by mid-30s · subsample, n = 47

Barrier 01

Economic costs

The 'good childrearing' standard internalised from their own singleton upbringing — from formula to school-district housing. They cannot bring themselves to halve that investment.

Barrier 02

Grandparent exhaustion

Near-universal dependence on grandparents for daily childcare. Grandparents are aging, losing capacity and energy. The childcare infrastructure is quietly eroding.

Barrier 03

Biological window closure

By the time finances stabilised, many women were approaching the age at which a second pregnancy felt medically risky. The window had quietly shut.

Case Studies & Policy Implications

Case: Jianying (corporate manager)

Conditions required:

- Two years persuading husband and in-laws
- Both parents live in; mother-in-law visits daily
- Secured flexible seniority position without pay cut
- Husband actively participates (rare exception)

Case: Haoyu (family business owner)

Conditions required:

- Wife closed her business; became full-time homemaker
- Accidental pregnancy overcame hesitation
- Consistent 10-year intention to have two children
- High household income + both sets of grandparents involved

The threshold is vanishingly high, while these conditions are structurally inaccessible to ordinary urban families

Policy implications:

- Relaxing birth restrictions is necessary but insufficient. The three-child policy had negligible effect on this cohort
- Effective fertility support requires: affordable public childcare + extended parental leave + educational cost subsidies - reducing the structural privatisation of childrearing

The Adaptive Persistence of Traditional Family Logic

Dimension	Surface form (modern)	Underlying continuity (traditional)	Source
Partner selection	Free individual romantic choice	Class endogamy — parental background shapes spousal access	Yang Hu (2016)
Sex preference	Feminist self-awareness; egalitarian ideology	Reproduction of patrilineal expectations via 'maternal duty'	Zhou Yun (2025)
Fertility behaviour	Individual cost-benefit reasoning	Structural privatisation of childrearing; state fails to support	Zhang et al. (2023)

Modernisation has not replaced traditional family norms — it has reconfigured their idiom while preserving their structural function

Answering the Problématique

Modernisation has substantially transformed the forms of traditional family norms; it has not yet dismantled their underlying logic.

Three core findings:

- Class background continues to structure marriage markets beyond individual educational sorting [Yang Hu]
- Gendered lived experience generates son preference through pathways invisible to conventional theory [Zhou Yun]
- The intention-behaviour fertility gap is structural, not individual — policy permissiveness alone cannot resolve it [Zhang et al.]

For discussion:

- When state demographic objectives (raise fertility) collide with structural constraints (cannot afford to), what institutional responses are available?
- Is this 'adaptive persistence' uniquely Chinese — or a universal feature of late-industrialising societies? (cf. South Korea TFR 0.72, Italy, Japan)
- Five years after the three-child policy: do these three studies' conclusions still hold in 2026?

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